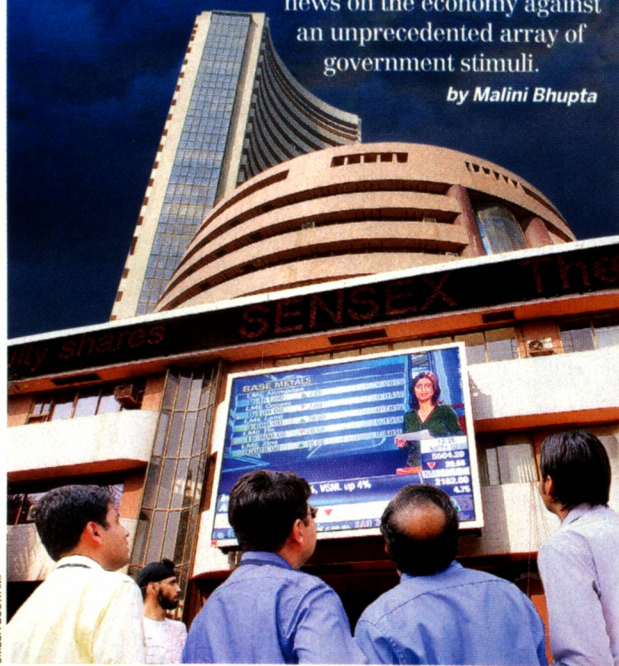


Down and UNDER

Sensex

For sheer unpredictability, nothing can vie with the Sensex. It rose spectacularly from 4,505 points in May 2004 to 21,000 at the beginning of the year only to plumb new depths. Having lost over 50 per cent of its gains, the Sensex is languishing around the 10,000-point mark. The pundits, who espoused the decoupling thesis which said that the emerging markets could prosper despite a slow-down in the developed world, have retreated into their burrows. As the subprime crisis and the subsequent credit crunch devoured large parts of the world, the Great India Story started turning sour as foreign institutional investors (FIIs) stated pulling out their India investments— \$13 billion (Rs 62,120 crore), to be exact. The ripple effects of the equity market crisis spilled over into the money markets; the rupee slid from a high of Rs 39 per dollar in January to Rs 48.50 now. By and large, equity meltdown is the villain behind the rupee's fall. Equity investors face a tug of war between deteriorating earnings prospects and increasingly attractive valuations. The next year promises to be no easier. Global growth is slowing and a number of countries are likely to go into recession. Markets are likely to remain extremely volatile as investors weigh up bad news on the economy against an unprecedented array of government stimuli.

by Malini Bhupta



AP

Because of Bindra, our athletes will now be able to stand on their marks in sport's biggest stage and say "Yes We Can".

Gold STANDARD

Abhinav Bindra

When Abhinav Bindra lined up his last shot in the Olympic 10m air rifle final, he would have seen his target and nothing else. A billion swearing Indians saw the bull's eye for it really was: the shackles of their unfortunate Olympic history. So when this laconic 25-year-old, with a ferocious appetite for work, fired his final bullet, he shattered the shackles and set Indian sport free. Never again would it be said that India and Olympic gold did not, could not, go together. Bindra's winning shot carried with it an echo that will forever resonate in the hearts and minds of every Indian athlete who puts on an Olympic uniform from this day on. Because of him, they will stand at their marks on the world's biggest stage in sport and will be able to say to themselves, "Yes, I can. Yes, it is possible". On his return from Beijing, Bindra was a little baffled by his country's joy, but he has used his position to speak frankly about not just his sport but all of Indian sport, and become the most forceful and legitimate of spokesmen for that most under-represented class: the Indian athlete.

by Sharda Ugra